i took a leap of faith (i should've stayed asleep instead)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32662126.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Gen, Other

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), catra is mentioned briefly

Additional Tags:
Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Hurt/Comfort, Self-Doubt, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Canon Compliant, all i'm saying is that this could've happened in canon, Healthy Communication, hey why isn't that a tag, Running Away, for a little bit because i don't do long-form fiction, listen you don't berserk like that and not have trauma, best friends squad feels are my fave, first chapter is bow and glimmer's pov, second chapter is adora's pov

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by grasstalker

Summary

Adora only remembers fragments from the Northern Reach.

One moment Catra was on the ground, and then red. And then pain. Shooting through her skull, so much that she couldn't focus on anything else. And then, nothing.

Well, not *nothing*.

She remembers attacking her friends. Glimmer popping in and out of existence, Bow with an unsteady grip on his tool. Catra on the ground again, face adorned with an expression of terror. And Adora swears that she can remember herself, sword in hand, about to strike down, *laughing*.

--
Or: The mission to the Northern Reach affected Adora more than anyone realized. Believing herself to be a danger to her friends, she flees.

Notes

My thoughts when I began writing this: "Okay but what if Adora had feelings about infected She-Ra?"

It got a little bit out of hand from there.

Title comes from Semi-Prologue by Action/Adventure. If you like punk rock, I highly recommend both the song and the band!

Bow and Glimmer

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After the mission to the Northern Reach, no one hears from Adora for a week.

It wasn't until after the first day had passed without sign of the girl that those in the castle grew concerned. Initially they assumed that she was simply sleeping; exposure to the virus clearly made her exhausted. But then she didn't come out the next day either. Not even for food. She may not have been in Bright Moon for very long, just some months, but Adora's absence was strikingly obvious to every resident of the castle.

When Glimmer, concerned and impulsive, had popped into Adora's quarters with her trademark shine, she had been met with a silent Adora, curled up in the middle of her bed with her back against the wall, almost blending into it given how dark the room was. The princess had summoned a glowing light into her palm, only slightly illuminating the space.

"Adora? What are you doing in here?" Glimmer had asked, "Are you okay? Everyone's been looking for you—we've been worried sick!"

The only response Glimmer had received was Adora tightening her arms around her knees even further, straining her neck even more as she buried her face into her legs.

Something about the situation had made Glimmer uneasy, but she wasn't going to leave without at least hearing her friend's voice. Preferably, she'd wanted to get her out of the room, but with the way Adora had coiled in on herself, gripping so tightly as if she was going to die if she loosened her fingers, perhaps that wasn't going to be an option.

Not that Glimmer would ever give up so easily. She'd come her friend's room for a reason, and when the princess made up her mind on something, she'd move mountains to reach her goal.

Glimmer had started moving towards the bed, towards Adora, continuing, "I'm sorry for barging into your room like this, I know you don't like it when I do that, but it's been two days since anyone's even seen you. Have you even gotten anything to eat at all?"

And once again, Glimmer's inquiries were met with silence. At least, that had been the case until she'd reached the foot of the bed.

"I'm fine." Adora had finally said, though Glimmer could hardly hear it because of how quiet and muffled the girl's voice was.

"What?" Glimmer had inched a little closer. Clearly Adora had not been fine, or she wouldn't have locked herself in her bedroom for two days. She hadn't necessarily *liked* the idea that popped into her head next, but perhaps it would be the only way to get her friend out of this funk, she'd thought. All she would need to do is just reach over, touch her arm, use a little bit of power that she'd recharge later.

"I'm fine," Adora had repeated, a little more force behind it than before, "Don't worry about me."

Sitting on the bed next to her friend, Glimmer had shaken her head, "Listen, Adora, I love you, but you're lying. 'Fine' doesn't equal whatever this is."

Adora had lifted her head slightly at the remark, but her eyes never met her friend's. "Really, it's fine," she'd said slowly, "you don't need to check up on me."

Her friend's stubborn insistence had caused Glimmer to quickly make up her mind about what to do.

“I’m sorry, Adora, I don’t know what’s wrong, but we need to get you out of here, you need to eat!” Glimmer had grabbed Adora’s arm, ready to teleport out of the room, but the moment her hand made contact she regretted it. Adora’s head had shot up, her eyes had been wild, flashing between millions of emotions at once before it had settled on what Glimmer could only assume was anger. It had looked completely foreign on Adora’s face.

Adora had slapped Glimmer’s hand away quickly, retreating from the touch just as fast.

“No! I already told you, I’m *fine*!” Adora had said, a tremble present in her voice, “Now get out!”

“But—"

The way that Adora had looked at her sent chills down Glimmer’s spine, “Get out!”

Glimmer had teleported away immediately after that. She’d been more confused than ever. What had she done to make Adora so angry?

It wasn’t until later, when she’d discussed the encounter with Bow, that she realized that the chilling look Adora gave her wasn’t one of anger or repugnance. It was one of fear.

“I’m leaving Bright Moon.”

The room falls silent. Mere minutes ago, this was a strategy meeting like any other for the Rebellion. But then their missing champion showed up at the door, and then the conversation turned into nothing short of an interrogation of their hero. And now, this.

The silence, naturally, is broken by the princess of Bright Moon, who stands so fast her chair screeches against the floor. “What? Adora what are you saying? You can’t do that!” As Glimmer continues, her initial tone of defiance turns into one of

desperation. She's known Adora for some time now, she knows that she's as stubborn as she is. And with the way her voice strained as she addressed the council, as well as the way her hands clench at her side, Glimmer knows that a battle of wills is fast-approaching. Perhaps it's already arrived.

At Glimmer's side, Bow pleads, "Adora, please, we should talk about this. You don't have to leave…" he trails off, unsure of what to say next. He's more than aware that something has had Adora shaken up this last week, but he doesn't know what. He has a guess, sure, but he hasn't exactly had a chance to talk to his friend at all. He didn't dare after hearing Glimmer's story about the harrowing look in Adora's eyes.

"There's nothing to talk about," Adora spits through gritted teeth, "I've made my decision, I just needed to let you all know." She looks down and away, adding, "I'm sorry."

Bow hates how tense Adora looks. Sure, in the time that he's known her she's never been a relaxed person, per se, but whereas her normal way of carrying herself is strong, determined, something that fills the space, the aura that surrounds her now is tight, constricting. It's like she's making herself small.

Adora leaves the room, and after taking a moment to nod to each other, Glimmer and Bow are right on her heels, letting the meeting fall into chaos behind them.

Their friend walks quickly, determination to leave etched into her steps.

"Adora? Wait!"

The girl pauses, but she doesn't look behind her. Glimmer almost moves to walk in front of her, but at the last moment she balks, still remembering the way the girl had glared at her the last time she got so close. So, for now, she settles on speaking to the back of a red jacket.

"Adora, please! What about us? After everything we've been through together, you're just going to leave us?" Glimmer pleads, hoping that maybe this will get her friend to turn around. She adds, a bit to her own surprise, "Aren't we the Best Friends Squad?"

Impossibly, Adora's back seems to stiffen even more. Well, both Glimmer and Bow think, at least it's a reaction.

"Glimmer's right, Adora," Bow says, "We're your friends. Please, you can tell us anything, you can just tell us what's bothering you. We promise we're going to help you through it."

A pause, until finally, "You shouldn't."

Bow takes a tentative step towards Adora, "Shouldn't what?"

Adora shakes her head, almost violently. "Shouldn't be friends… with me." The words are said slowly, enough that despite their coldness, Bow can hear the real emotions lying beneath them. He can tell that they don't come from a place of malice or hate. At least, not towards himself and Glimmer.

While he ruminates on that, Glimmer, his complement, doesn't have the same issue, "What, that's ridiculous! Why wouldn't we be friends with you? All you've ever done is show how much you care about people! And besides, it's our choice to be your friend. We're gonna stick with you no matter what!"

That gets Adora to finally turn around, but while Bow and Glimmer were expecting to see some kind of emotion on her face, what they find instead is a carefully blank expression, eyes so dull that they're almost lifeless. Adora looks…defeated. And it looks *wrong*.

Bow and Glimmer had grown up in a place where touch meant comfort. It meant love. So, seeing Adora, their friend, their best friend, like this…all it made them want to do is reach out, grab her shoulders, hug her. But they couldn't. Despite Adora's expression,

there was something in her eyes that also told them to stay away. It was faint, but there, nonetheless.

Adora's dull eyes move towards a spot on the ground, "Then you guys should let me do this. It's…" she stops, lips pursing. "It's to protect you guys."

"How is you leaving going to protect us? Have you forgotten that you're literally She-Ra? The rebellion needs She-Ra!" Glimmer shouts.

Bow nods, "Yeah, Adora, the rebellion needs you. We need you. Just tell us what's going on. I don't think there's anything we need to be protected from."

"And even if there is, whoever it is, we'll just kick their butt!" Glimmer says, punching her fist into her palm for emphasis.

A ghost of a smile flits onto Adora's face for half a second, until the mask goes up again.

"No, I don't think so," Adora looks up at Bow, eyes showing more emotion than he'd seen from her in the last week, "Please, this is the only way I can protect you guys from—" She stops herself.

Bow moves takes another step forward, but this time Adora immediately backsteps away from the movement, so he stays in place. "From what, Adora?"

"From—oh, it doesn't matter! I've just got to go, and then you all will be safe." Adora exclaims, frustration lining her voice, composure melting from the anger simmering underneath.
Or, no, not anger. Fear. At least probably, Bow and Glimmer aren't sure.

"You can at least tell us why you're just going to abandon us then!" Glimmer shouts, now her composure's cracking, though this is definitely from an explosive temper. She doesn't mean to get angry so quickly, but people leaving is not something she can

react to peacefully anymore. Not since she became the daughter of a single parent.

Bow worriedly glances between his two best friends, who also both happen to be the most stubborn people he's ever met. Glimmer, who's demanding tone stems from concern, and Adora, who continues to bottle up her feelings. It's a clash of wills, and while he typically tries not to get between the two when they get like this, he's afraid that this time it is simply necessary.

He doesn't want to lose Adora to whatever demons cloud her mind.

However, he will, at least, show his friend a bit more bedside manner. "Glimmer might be a little harsh, but she's right Adora. Don't you think it's a little unfair that you're going to leave without an explanation?"

That gets Adora to visibly soften a bit, a couple lines of tension leaving her forehead, so he tries again, "What do you want to protect us from?"

"I—uh…" Adora wears a look that Bow would almost say is of shame.

Next to the boy, Glimmer makes a slight huff. She and Bow have been friends for years, and one thing has become clear in all that time it is that she does not have the same patience of him. Not for lack of trying on either of their parts, but Glimmer is simply a woman of action.

And right now, watching her friend be so deeply shaken by something she refuses to give a voice to, she finds that she is at her limit. Of course, she doesn't quite like the sharp sound of her voice when she speaks again, but what can she do? She wants Adora to feel better and she wants her to know that as her best friends, she and Bow will do anything to make that happen.

"Just spit it out Adora!"

Before Bow can lightly chastise Glimmer, Adora shouts, "From *me*, okay?!"

At the admission, any thoughts or plans of both archer and princess come to a screeching halt, and they both find that they have no response. Glimmer makes to mutter some sort of question, though after pushing through the sudden tightness in her throat it comes out less as words and more of a "Wha…?"

At first, both Bow and Glimmer are utterly lost. Why would Adora even think that? They each comb through memories of the past week, trying to figure out what could pain Adora so. With all the worrying of the last seven days, they find that they're having trouble remembering.

But then another moment passes, and for Bow, realization sinks in his chest like a stone.

"Oh, Adora, this isn't about what happened at the Northern Reach, is it?" he asks, though he's sure he already knows the answer. And with the way Adora slowly turns her head away from him, he understands that he's right. But for once, he finds no gratification in that fact.

Bow's first thought is confusion. If this is about what happened at the Northern Reach, then Adora, despite her tendency to irrationally hold herself responsible for everything, should understand that She-Ra only rampaged after the introduction of that virus to her sword, that it was some foreign entity that changed her in such a way. She should know that—

Wait, does Adora know that? The virus had affected her memory last time, at Dryl, maybe she couldn't completely remember what happened. The girl had almost immediately shut herself into her room once they returned to Bright Moon, Bow remembered, so they had never gotten a chance to explain what happened. How First Ones' tech had infected She-Ra's sword, doing something to the warrior's psyche as well. But if Adora doesn't know that she was under the influence of essentially a virus, then…what

conclusions might she have drawn in the last week? Bow isn't sure he wants to know the answer.

Glimmer seems to be thinking something similar, as she says, "Adora, that…that wasn't you, you know that, right?" Her voice has lost all the fire from before, seeing how upset her friend is. Now, she takes in where they are—in a hallway in the castle, somewhere decidedly not private. Without thinking, Glimmer moves to lightly touch Adora's arm, the way she'd always touch Bow's whenever they were having a more serious conversation. She doesn't even realize what she's doing until she sees Adora's violent flinch away from her.

"What are you doing?" Adora says, voice laced with fear, fear that Bow and Glimmer finally understand. Glimmer watches as her friend makes a feeble attempt to maintain her composure, before forgoing it altogether. Her eyes fill with emotion again, but nothing that Glimmer wants to see.

It's a nasty thing, in those eyes. Like a cornered animal warding others away. They were also unfocused, flitting between Bow and Glimmer and seemingly nothing at all.

"You guys were there, you saw what happened, what if it happens again?"

"That won't happen, Adora, the disk is destroyed, it can't hurt you anymore." Bow says.

Adora smiles, but it's a broken smile, one filled with not a trace of mirth, "Who cares about it hurting me, I almost hurt you!" She backsteps, away from the concern of Bow and Glimmer, "We don't know if, when, this will happen again! This is the only way I can make sure everyone's safe!" Her voice grows more panicked, her pitch more unconstrained with each passing word.

"But what about you?" Glimmer says, feeling tears pinprick at the corners of her eyes. She isn't sure why they're coming on, whether it was frustration or sadness at seeing her friend in this

state. “No one here wants you to leave! No one here blames you for the effects of some virus! Can’t you see that?”

“Don’t you get it! I almost *killed* you, both of you! And I was going to kill Catra—and I was getting some-some sick enjoyment out of it! I-I—!” Adora keeps backing up until she hits the wall, shaking some of the paintings adorning it. She wraps her arms around herself. Her breathing is hard, her eyes unfocused.

This is bad. Adora is panicking. She isn’t hearing them. Bow rushes forward, hoping that Adora isn’t in a state to flee from the action. “Adora! Adora, just breathe for a second.”

At Bow’s words, Adora’s eyes squeeze shut, and she slides down the wall, landing on the ground ungracefully, tucked in herself. Bow positions himself in front of her, Glimmer joining on her side. Slowly her eyes blink open again, and for the first time that day (and truly for the first time ever since Bow and Glimmer have known her) Adora’s eyes aren’t shielded by some sort of invisible wall.

“Guys…” Adora whimpers, eyes holding a depth almost as deep as the sea, overflowing with emotions that Bow and Glimmer can’t completely place, but they’re okay with that. They can talk about all that later. For now, they’re content with the fact that Adora has chosen to show any vulnerability at all.

“Please, Adora, stay.” Bow says pleadingly and calmly. He hesitates for a second before resting his hand on her shoulder, Glimmer following suit on the other side. Adora only makes a slight movement at this, causing the two to feel a bit more hopeful that they’ve gotten through to Adora.

Careful silence lingers for a moment, like a trance. Adora glances between Bow and Glimmer, though something about her expression makes it seem as though her mind was still elsewhere. Glimmer gives her a reassuring smile, knowing that perhaps adding more words to the situation would break the spell.

Adora's lips twitch, a smile almost, *almost* tugging at the edge—but then she shakes her head almost like she's pulling herself from a dream. Blue eyes, although still laced in fear, harden.

"No! You…you have to stay away from me!" Adora pushes Bow away, causing him to lose his balance. Glimmer quickly removes her hand from Adora's shoulder, moving over to Bow's side to help him get up. Adora scrambles to her feet, "I'm dangerous! I don't want to hurt anyone else! Please…I'm sorry…just please, you need to stay away!"

Adora pivots on her foot and sprints in the opposite direction, moving swiftly, her strong body carrying her away.

"Wait—!" Glimmer calls out behind her, before Bow puts a hand on her shoulder. She gets ready to teleport them both to catch up with her, but Bow stops the princess.

"Don't. We should…we should give her some space."

"But she's already had space for a whole week and now she's gone!"

"I know, but she's not going to listen to us now. We'll have to talk to her later."

"How are going to find her? We don't know where she's going!"

Bow is silent, heart aching as he listens to the last echoes Adora's frantic footsteps fully fade away. Eventually, though, he sighs, "I don't know. But we'll find her."

The pair make to head back the way they came, their footsteps and their echoes being the only sounds filling the large hallway. Muffled voices break the silence as they approach the council room, but without even so much as a glance at each other, Bow and Glimmer both know that they can't face returning to the meeting.

They walk past the hardly contained chaos, continuing until they reach Adora's room, where the door is ajar. A whirlwind of feelings overcomes them both, curiosity leading the charge, and so they peer inside.

It's spotless. Not that Adora ever leaves her bedroom in disarray, but the cleanliness present here is clinical, like no one lives here after all.

Slightly ahead of Bow, Glimmer pushes the door open and walks inside. She doesn't know what she's, what they're, doing in here. Combing the place won't make their friend come back. But even as she thinks this, she finds herself moving deeper in the space. Had it been this clean when she checked on Adora? Had she been planning to leave this whole time?

Her eyes move around, taking in the sight. She hears a slight inhale beside her. Bow. Before she can ask what's wrong, her gaze falls upon what she's sure caused his reaction.

The Sword of Protection sits on Adora's bed. Polished, gleaming, and far away from the only person who could use it.

"We've got to find Adora," The Princess of Brightmoon states. It's only been a few hours since Adora ran off, but time has been agonizingly slow for the pink-haired girl.

Bow only hums in response from his position below Glimmer's lofted bed, prompting her to continue.

"I know you said we should give her space, but anything could happen to her out there!" Glimmer teleports down in front of her friend, hands waving exasperatedly. "We don't even know where she is!"

"I know, I know, but you saw how she was, there was no way we were going to get through to her then."

"Fine, but I'm not going to sit around anymore, we're finding Adora. Now."

The duo start thinking of places their friend could have gone. They hope that Adora at least had a destination in mind, that she isn't going to wander aimlessly, but knowing the blonde, it's very possible that that is exactly what she's doing at this very moment.

"The Whispering Woods." Bow and Glimmer realize simultaneously. To them, it made sense. The Whispering Woods is vast, and easy to get lost in. Adora was probably there, it wasn't too far from the castle. Finding their friend there would be hard, but together they can do it. Probably.

"Let's go."

Some hours later, Bow and Glimmer are in the Woods, weaving through the trees in vines in search of the missing member of their trio. They decided on the way over to be quiet, to not alert Adora of their presence in case she decides to flee even further away.

Glimmer hates it. She wants to be loud. She wants Adora to know that they're there, that they're looking for her, that they care. That they aren't scared of some disk that's destroyed now.

They continue like that for some time, until Glimmer spots a head of blonde hair peeking from underbrush. Luckily, Bow is close by, so all she must do is make a motion for him to come (carefully) running over.

Adora is curled up, back against a tree trunk. Her hair's disheveled, probably messed up on the run from Brightmoon to the woods. The back of her jacket is covered in dirt, but only the back, like she's been sitting in this position for hours.

The pair share a look, using their skill built from years of friendship to silently have a conversation. They decide to get a

little closer to Adora, so she doesn't have the chance to run away again.

As much as Glimmer wants to yell Adora's name and possibly even tackle the girl, she keeps her composure. The situation requires delicacy, and if going against her immediate desires is what gets Adora to come back home, she'll do it.

The pair quietly draw closer, and Glimmer can't help but feel like they're predators approaching their prey. She doesn't like it, acting as though Adora would whoosh away the second a twig snapped, but considering what happened this morning, perhaps the caution is warranted, she thinks.

The two are close enough to Adora that they're surprised they haven't been noticed yet. Sharing a glance, they decide to test the waters, see if their presence won't be met with fleeing.
"Adora?" Bow quietly calls out.

The blonde's head snaps to them quickly, so very startled. Clearly, she wasn't expecting them at all. She uncurls herself somewhat, probably getting ready to run away again.

"What-" she starts, looking at Bow and Glimmer but not meeting their concerned eyes. "What are you guys doing here?"

"We were looking for you. Do you really think we'd just let you run away?" Glimmer says, irritation slowly creeping into her voice, even though she's trying to keep it at bay. First priority is getting Adora back to Brightmoon safely, she can chew her out later.

"Yes!" Now it's Adora's turn to look exasperated as she jumps to her feet, "I already told you, I'm doing this for your safety!"

"Don't we get a say in this too? What about your safety Adora? How are you going to live out here in the woods?"

"I'll figure it out." Adora mumbles, which only seems to rile up Glimmer more. Before the princess can say anything though, Bow puts a grounding hand on her shoulder.

“Okay, clearly arguing like this won’t get us anywhere,” Bow sighs, “But Adora, can you please just hear us out? We didn’t come all this way just to start another shouting match.”

Adora looks tired. Bags line underneath her eyes. With a defeated sigh, she slinks back down to the ground, arms wrapped around her legs. She tilts her head to her side, “Fine, go ahead.”

Bow and Glimmer join Adora on the ground, trying to figure out their next move.

Unsurprisingly, it’s Glimmer who goes first, “You know, seeing She-Ra like that in the Northern Reach…it was scary. I mean, it didn’t seem like you were in there at all.”

Adora curls in tighter on herself at the same time Bow gives the pink-haired girl a chastising whisper-shouted “Glimmer!”

“Wait! I’m not done. Yes, it was scary. And yes, when She-Ra elbowed me, it hurt! Kinda a lot…” Glimmer trails off, before determination sets into her eyes again. “But that wasn’t you. That wasn’t your fault! When that happened, I wasn’t thinking ‘oh Adora’s dangerous now’ or whatever you’ve told yourself in your head. I was just worried about you, worried about how this disk would affect you, whether you would even come back.”

Adora is silent after the admission. Truly, the whole Woods seem to be, with the only sounds coming from Glimmer’s awkward shuffling in her wait for a reply.

Bow speaks up, “Glimmer and I aren’t scared of you, Adora. And even if She-Ra going beserk was something you had any agency over, we still wouldn’t be. You’d never hurt us on purpose, would you?”

The blonde jumps at that, “No, never!”

“Exactly, so why would we be afraid? We know you Adora. What happened in the Northern Reach, that wasn’t you. That wasn’t on you.”

The red-clad girl shakes her head, “But I’m She-Ra, so wasn’t it me? I’m the one responsible.”

“No,” Bow and Glimmer say together, patience and passion coming together.

Adora looks at Glimmer and Bow briefly, before turning her gaze back in front of her. She sighs, an almost defeated sound, “I just don’t get it.”

Bow reaches out and puts a hand on her shoulder. Surprisingly, she doesn’t flinch away from the touch, “Get what?”

“Why are you guys are being so nice to me? I failed, I failed. As She-Ra, I’m supposed to protect you guys, but all I did was attack you because Catra tricked me! If I had figured out their plan sooner…”

“Adora, there’s no way you could’ve guessed that they were going to do that to you. None of us saw it coming.”

“But…”

“No buts!” Glimmer cuts in, “Just because you’re She-Ra doesn’t mean you have to be perfect, that you have to be all-knowing or whatever.”

Adora finally looks at her friends, worry evident in her eyes, “How can you be so sure this won’t happen again?”

“We won’t let it,” Glimmer says, resolute. “The disk may be gone, but we’ll make sure no one gets any tech even close to your sword again.”

“Glimmer’s right. If anyone failed at the Northern Reach, it’s us for letting the Horde do that to you. We won’t be making that mistake again.” Bow smiles, an invitation to lighter feelings, “The Best Friends Squad looks out for each other.”

A moment passes and finally, finally, Adora gives a genuine smile, complete with a light laugh, "We do, don't we?"

"That's the spirit!" Bow says, rising to his feet while holding his hand out so Adora can do the same, "Now, sounds to me like it's time for a—"

"Group hug!" Glimmer finishes, immediately almost tackling Adora right back to the forest floor with the force of her hug. Bow joins in once the part-time warrior goddess regains her footing.

After a minute, the hug loosens, and Adora looks at her two best friends. "I'm sorry for making you guys worry."

Glimmer waves the apology off, "We did worry, but there's no need to apologize." While she reassures Adora, the princess mentally removes chewing her friend out about running away off her to-do list. That wouldn't do anything but make her feel worse, and there's been enough of that today.

"Yeah," Bow agrees, "and new rule. No more saying sorry, especially because you say it for things that weren't even your fault."

"Sor-" Bow gives Adora a (mostly fake) stern look, "Right, right. No more 'sorry's."

"Now, why don't we get back home?" Glimmer suggests, "The Woods are pretty, but the only thing I wanna see right now are my pillows."

"I'd much rather see your pillows than mine, I think I've been seeing a little too much of my room lately." Adora says, following Bow and Glimmer as they begin the trek back to Brightmoon.

Bow gasps, "You know what this calls for—Best Friends Squad sleepover!"

The trio's cheers and laughter can be heard well into the night.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you all enjoyed! I'm not completely satisfied with it, but writing this already took me 4 months so I just didn't want to put it off anymore.

There will actually be a second part to this story, with Adora's POV (that's where the summary comes from, that's a paraphrased segment of that chapter). Hopefully that will be out soon, since I love writing character's thought processes so much, especially Adora's. But I thought it would be better to do Bow and Glimmer's perspective first.

If you enjoyed, be sure to leave kudos, and, if you're so inclined, maybe a comment? I love reading what you all have to say. The comments I got on my last fic were literally so nice I had serotonin pumping for days.

Oh, and before I leave, fun fact: I headcanon Bow as someone who deals with anxiety along with Adora. That's why he recognizes what's up with Adora quickly and has that tip to get her to calm down at the ready. Especially in high school, I had really bad anxiety, so I kinda based that off of my own experience.

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Adora

Chapter Summary

There is another way to tell this story.

TW: Panic attack, very subtle/minor suicidal thoughts.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Fragments.

That's all Adora remembers from the mission at the Northern Reach. She'd been fighting Catra, trying to subdue her, like always. Their clashes are never serious, at least not on Adora's side (though she'd bet that Catra never fights seriously against her either, other than the one time her claws pierced her back). Everyone knows she holds back as She-Ra. But it was different this time.

One moment Catra was on the ground, and then red. And then pain. Shooting through her skull, so much that she couldn't focus on anything else. And then, nothing.

Well, not *nothing*.

She remembers swinging her sword, harder and faster than she ever would normally because she always holds back. Charging at her friends who begged her to let go of the weapon. Glimmer popping in and out of existence, Bow with an unsteady grip on his tool.

The last thing she can remember before detransforming is seeing Catra on the ground again, but this time she wasn't smiling her usual smug grin. No, on her face was an expression of terror. Eyes looking at her, pleading. And Adora swears that she can remember herself, sword in hand, about to strike down, *laughing*.

Adora lays on her bed, sprawled out like one of those starfish creatures at Salineas. She doesn't know how long she's been in this position. It feels like it could have been hours, but for a restless girl like her, it could have just as easily been minutes.

She would move, except she can't. She's caught, reliving again and again those fragments from the Northern Reach. She continually tries to edge the memories further, try to remember just one more detail each time they replay. But additional context eludes her. All she can remember is the sequence of red, pain, attack. It drones in her head, and all she can think about is that she *failed.*

Something happened, and she lost control of She-Ra.
Her responsibility, *her* destiny. She came so, so close to hurting her friends. So, so close to hurting her…Catra.

It didn't matter what caused her to lose control, though she guessed it was the same tech that affected her at Dryl. The fact is she was affected. She was corrupted, infected, *tainted*, and who knows if and when this would happen again. She clearly wasn't good enough to stop it.

She's tainted She-Ra. She-Ra isn't supposed to go berserk. She isn't supposed to only destroy.

Or what if she was?

What if Adora is the only reason She-Ra hasn't been destroying everything she touched? Maybe she really is just a weapon, a weapon that Adora has been asked to wield. One that she can't wield. One that she can't control.

That scares Adora more than anything. Not that she's afraid of being a weapon. She's been one her entire life. The Horde raised soldiers, not children.

No, she's scared that she's a weapon that she isn't worthy to wield. That she isn't *able* to wield.

Adora gets up from off her back, and based on the way her body aches, she thinks that she's been in her room for days.

She doesn't know what to do, but she knows she doesn't want to leave this room. Not when she's a danger to everyone around her. Losing control happened so swiftly, there's no telling when it would happen again.

The girl backs to the wall, and curls in on herself.

She stares at her hands. The calloused results of being a soldier most of her life stare back at her. Even though She-Ra is a warrior, her hands are soft. Unblemished, untouched. Not now though. Adora fears that were she to transform again, her hands, She-Ra's hands, they'd be wrong somehow. Perhaps she didn't draw blood at the Reach but it still feels that way all the same.

She can't stand to look at her hands anymore. She wraps them around her legs and grips tightly.

Here in her ball, she's safe. She can't hurt anybody.

Just as she's starting to find marginal comfort in the position, Adora feels more than sees a bright flash accompanied by a shift in the air.

"Adora? What are you doing in here? Are you okay? Everyone's been looking for you—we've been worried sick!"

Hands dig into skin even further. Ah, Glimmer. What could she say to her? Say to the person that she attacked? Betrayed? She decides to say nothing. Maybe Glimmer will realize how dangerous Adora is and leave.

"I'm sorry for barging into your room like this, I know you don't like it when I do that, but it's been two days since anyone's even seen you. Have you even gotten anything to eat at all?"

That briefly pulls Adora's attention from her self-loathing; no, she supposes, she hasn't eaten. Hasn't exactly had the energy or will

to even get off the bed. She wonders if they have taken to leaving plates outside her door. She would ask, but she feels ice from the Reach blocking her throat.

All she can do in the face of it is squeak out two little words, "I'm fine."

"What?"

Why couldn't Glimmer just leave? The ice melts ever so slightly from the irritation, "I'm fine. Don't worry about me."

A weight joins her on the bed, and it takes all of Adora's energy not to flinch away. She doesn't want Glimmer, her friend (though is she truly worthy of calling her that?), to worry about her even more. She just wants her to leave her, leave her before she hurts her. Again.

"Listen, Adora, I love you, but you're lying. 'Fine' doesn't equal whatever this is."

Adora lifts her head slightly, but she can't bring herself to look at another person she's hurt. "Really, it's fine. You don't need to check up on me."

"I'm sorry, Adora, I don't know what's wrong, but we need to get you out of here, you need to eat!"

All of a sudden, an arm is on Adora, and she hates it. It's so cold it *burns*, colder than all the snow and ice at the Reach, than the snow thrown into her face by Catra when she—

She needs it off, she needs it gone!

Her eyes lock onto the girl in front of her and she slaps her hand away, guilt being overwhelmingly drowned out by panic and terror. The ice melts completely from their combined force.

"No! I already told you, I'm *fine*! Now get out!"

“But—”

“Get out!”

Adora watches as her friend immediately pops out of existence. Far away from her, probably. Her heart is still beating fast, pumping in her ears. She allows herself a few moments to breathe before she even thinks about anything.

When the moment passes and the adrenaline dies down, Adora finds that she can only feel more guilt and shame. Never in her life had she acted so…primal. Acted on such instinct. It scares her.

She’s lost control of She-Ra and now she can’t even control her own temper when in normal form. There really is something wrong and dangerous about her. She’s no better than a beast.

The next few days go like this: Adora spends 99% of the day on her bed, not wanting to move, not wanting to be touched, not wanting to be seen. Door closed, except for those fleeting moments where she’ll snatch the plate of food on the other side of it. She doesn’t want anyone to be around her, but nothing can stop the rumbling of her stomach.

She knows she can’t continue on like this, and during this time she has come to a conclusion. She must leave Brightmoon. She must leave the Rebellion. It’s the only way everyone, Bow and Glimmer, can be safe.

She is unpredictable. She could lose control of She-Ra at anytime, obviously.

An uncontrolled She-Ra is a useless one, just like any weapon.

She doesn’t want to be a weapon. Anymore.

So, today, a week since the mission, she finally gets up from her bed knowing that it will be the last time she sleeps in it.

Adora puts her room in order, not that it was that dirty anyway. She doesn't want to leave a mess for the staff to clean up when she goes.

She leaves her sword.

Adora had forgotten how bright the castle truly was, she realizes as she steps outside her room. It takes her eyes a minute to adjust.

She just has to find Queen Angella. Let her know of her plans. And then she can leave. Hopefully the Queen will be alone, she isn't sure that she could face Bow and Glimmer now.

She hates to disappoint the Rebellion like that, but she'd rather disappoint than end up hurting them more.

Walking through the large, regal halls of the castle, she periodically sees guards on either side of her. Sometimes various castle staff also walk past her on her way to find the Queen as well.

Normally, this would be no issue.

But today, everyone, even the normally stoic guards, look at her with surprise in their eyes. She hates it. She hates that she didn't expect news of her being a danger not to spread. Especially after shouting at Glimmer, everyone's probably scared of her now. Wary.

They probably should be, of course, but she still finds herself suffocating under their widened eyes.

Eventually Adora starts to hear the muffled sounds of a conversation from one of the upcoming rooms. Based on some of the words she can make out, she assumes this must be a Rebellion meeting. Not ideal, but Queen Angella would be there, and she can't wait any longer.

She walks into the room. Immediately, all eyes are on her, and a barrage of questions fly her way. She doesn't listen to any of them.

Instead, she speaks the line she so carefully practiced, "I'm leaving Bright Moon."

She looks down at the floor, unable to meet anyone's surely disappointed gaze.

"What? Adora what are you saying? You can't do that!" Glimmer speaks first, as always.

"Adora, please, we should talk about this. You don't have to leave…" Bow, also as always, follows his friend.

Adora looks up for a second but is forced to look away after seeing the devastation in Bow and Glimmer's eyes. She steels herself to speak again, teeth gritted all the while. "There's nothing to talk about, I've made my decision." A pause. "I'm sorry."

She pivots and is out the door. There, she's said it. Now it's time for her to get out of here so she won't be a danger or a disappointment anymore. She doesn't know where she's going, she'll figure it out.

"Adora? Wait!"

Of course this wouldn't be easy. Nothing ever is. Adora stops, but she still can't bring herself to look at the pair who followed her out here.

"Adora, please! What about us? After everything we've been through together, you're just going to leave us?" Glimmer says, and Adora really wishes she'd been able to speak to Queen Angella alone. "Aren't we the Best Friends Squad?"

No, don't say that. Friends? What kind of friend would attack their friends so viciously? They should just let her go.

“Glimmer’s right, Adora,” Bow says, “We’re your friends. Please, you can tell us anything, you can just tell us what’s bothering you. We promise we’re going to help you through it.”

It seems they won’t let her leave in peace. She doesn’t understand why. Don’t they know this is what’s best for everybody? Adora breathes in, giving herself a moment to collect her thoughts. “You shouldn’t.”

“Shouldn’t what?” Bow says.

Adora shakes her head, “Shouldn’t be friends…with me.” She hates how much effort it takes to get the words out.

“What, that’s ridiculous! Why wouldn’t we be friends with you? All you’ve ever done is show how much you care about people! And besides, it’s our choice to be your friend. We’re gonna stick with you no matter what!” Glimmer sounds determined. If it weren’t for the situation, Adora would appreciate that.

She turns around, albeit reluctantly. She carefully keeps her expression blank, not wanting to give anything away,

Adora notices Bow make an aborted movement, as if he was going to reach out to her, maybe. She looks away.

“Then you guys should let me do this. It’s…” What should she say? Does she admit to her failure, her shame? “It’s to protect you guys.”

That only serves to further incense Glimmer, “How is you leaving going to protect us? Have you forgotten that you’re literally She-Ra?” *No*. “The rebellion needs She-Ra!”

Bow nods along with his friend, “Yeah, Adora, the rebellion needs you. We need you.” *No*, *you don’t*, she wants to say. “Just tell us what’s going on. I don’t think there’s anything we need to be protected from.”

“And even if there is, whoever it is, we’ll just kick their butt!”

Adora almost smiles at that, she can feel her lips slightly turning up. Then she kicks herself for indulging in even that. She can feel herself start second-guessing her decision, being lulled into a false sense of security. She needs to leave. Now.

"No, I don't think so." She looks to Bow, who would hopefully be the more rational of the two, "Please, this is the only way I can protect you guys from—"

Bow moves closer to her, but Adora quickly steps away. She won't be lulled.

"From what, Adora?"

She was really hoping they wouldn't start asking that. "From—oh, it doesn't matter! I've just got to go, and then you all will be safe." Can they please just drop it and let her leave now? She feels frustration starting to bleed into her voice, and she wonders if emotion has anything to do with her loss of control. Why didn't she think of that before? Could she be putting her friends in danger again just by *feeling* things?

"You can at least tell us why you're going to abandon us then!" Glimmer shouts, temporarily interrupting Adora's spiral. That doesn't stop her from starting to worry again though. She wants—no *needs*—to get out of here.

"Glimmer might be a little harsh, but she's right Adora. Don't you think it's a little unfair that you're going to leave without an explanation?"

Yes. No. Adora doesn't know, and she really doesn't want to think about it. Not when her friends are stopping her form doing the only thing she can to protect them. To save them.

Bow speaks again, "What do you want to protect us from?"

Is this it? Will she have to admit to it? "I—uh…"

Glimmer huffs and shouts, "Just spit it out Adora!"

From me, *okay* ?! Adora thinks. But she doesn't want to admit it. Silence fills the hall as she struggles to think of an answer to Glimmer.

But then Glimmer lets out a noise, almost like a "wha…?", and oh, she said that out loud.

Bow's the first to break the silence (other than Glimmer's aborted words), "Oh, Adora, this isn't about what happened at the Northern Reach, is it?"

Of course it is. She can't even bear to look at her friends as they figure it out themselves. She's surprised they didn't know sooner. She'd thought that they'd be afraid of her by now, having a whole week to mull over the same events she did.

"Adora, that…that wasn't you, you know that, right?" Glimmer says softly, and Adora finds that she preferred when she was yelling.

Adora wants to deny it. To pretend the last thirty seconds never happened. But they're here now aren't they? Maybe she can finally convince them of what she already knows to be true.

Out of the corner of her eye, she sees Glimmer moving towards her, almost touching her arm. It takes all of her self-control not to slap the offending limb away, but rather to just flinch backwards. "What are you doing?" Why would they try to touch her now? Even after knowing how dangerous she is? It doesn't make any sense!

"You guys were there, you saw what happened, what if it happens again?"

Bow shakes his head, "That won't happen, Adora, the disk is destroyed, it can't hurt you anymore."

The *disk*? Adora almost laughs, "Who cares about it hurting me, I almost hurt you!" She's saying too much, she just wants to leave.

“We don’t know if, when, this will happen again! This is the only way I can make sure everyone’s safe!”

“But what about you?” Glimmer says, disregarding Adora’s very clear reasoning, “No one here wants you to leave! No one here blames you for the effects of some virus! Can’t you see that?”

Why not? They should! Adora’s thoughts keep shortening, becoming more and more a monotonous, repeating line of *keep them safe*, *keep them safe.*

“Don’t you get it! I almost *killed* you, both of you! And I was going to kill Catra—and I was getting some—some sick enjoy me out of it! I-I—!”

Adora feels herself hit the wall, and she can’t form any new words. She just wants to get out of here, but she can’t will herself to move, her body betrays her. Her breath leaves her in droves, but she can’t seem to take in any new air, leaving her gasping. Her heart leaps in her chest.

All she can hear is her heartbeat, blood rushing in her ears.

She picks up something muffled in the background, “-dora! Just breathe for a second.”

Adora closes her eyes, and she feels her back against the wall, eventually feeling the floor under her.

When her eyes open again, Bow and Glimmer are in front of her.

“Guys…” Adora chokes out, trying to focus on the figures around her rather than on her panic. She’s too tired to shield herself from the onslaught of emotions.

“Please, Adora, stay.” Adora hears Bow say. A moment passes and he rests a hand on her shoulder, and Adora doesn’t brush it off. Exhaustion or acceptance. She feels another warm hand on her other shoulder, probably Glimmer’s.

Silence falls, and Adora sinks into it. She can't speak, all she can do is breathe. Bow's words echo in her mind. Because, underneath it all, she doesn't really want to leave. But her duty is to protect Etheria, protect her friends. And this is the only way she can do that.

If she didn't make the best choice, wouldn't that make her even more of a failure?

But she still doesn't want to go.

The thought of sticking through it with her friends makes her want to smile. She would if she wasn't so tired.

She looks between her friends, imagining what would happen if she decided to stay, if she didn't flee. She can see the future in their faces. Happy, content, maybe even victorious. Fighting battles together, winning battles together.

Yeah, she can see it. She can see—she can see—

—her hands stained with blood from a revolting use of her sword. Awareness coming back to her slowly as she sees what she's done, what she's become. Her name caught in the throats of her friends, and if they voice it, it's only voiced in contempt, horror, disgust.

"No!" Adora shakes herself from the vision. "You…you have to stay away from me!" She scrambles to her feet, pushing Bow away, because leave it to her to hurt her friends when they're trying to help her. "I'm dangerous! I don't want to hurt anyone else! Please…I'm sorry…just please, you need to stay away!"

She has to go. She pivots and runs.

An aborted call after her makes its way to her ears, but she doesn't acknowledge it. Just like she doesn't acknowledge the tears stinging her eyes as she runs, runs, runs.

Falling to the ground and panting, Adora realizes that she can't run anymore. She doesn't know how long it's been since that harrowing moment in the castle, and she can hardly think back to it as her lungs are burning.

She feels ashamed. She feels like a coward. Probably because she is. Who else flees? Who else abandons their post, their duty?

On the other hand, she knows she did it exactly for her post, for her duty. Running away is the only way to keep them safe from her, from her loss of control.

As an extra precaution, Adora decided not to bring She-Ra's (~~her~~) sword with her, because who knows what could happen if she transforms?

Taking a deep breath, Adora finally takes in her surroundings, noticing the thick leaves of the trees all around her. She must be in the Whispering Woods. Great, if she doesn't want to be found. Which, despite what she may say, she isn't sure she doesn't want to be.

It's funny, Adora thinks, as she slides her back down a tree trunk, that it's only just now that she has a problem with being She-Ra. Or, maybe that's not the right way of looking at it.

She's always felt disconnected from She-Ra in a way. How couldn't she? She-Ra hardly even looks like her, with her long, flowing locks and her much taller stature. But with the incident at the Northern Reach, it feels more than ever like She-Ra is another person. One that Adora did not agree to be stuck with. One that does whatever she desires before disappearing in a flash of light, leaving Adora to pick up the pieces.

So yes, she *had* to leave. Because she was unable to do her duty and help.

And while Adora knows that leaving was probably the right decision, she can't help but to think of how that's all she's good for. Hurting people and leaving.

She already hurt Catra when she left. And now here she goes again, hurting Bow and Glimmer by leaving.

Adora hears rustling beside her. Perhaps it's a wild animal she thinks. Maybe it will attack her. Maybe she should've brought the sword. Then again, she doesn't really have the energy or will to move. Maybe it will make it quick.

But then she hears a voice, and she realizes with a start that it's not some beast at all. "Adora?"

Of course they'd go after her. Bow and Glimmer were never good at just letting matters lie. She can't bring herself to look them in the eye, so she makes do with just their general direction. "What —what are you guys doing here?"

"We were looking for you. Do you really think we'd let you just run away?"

"Yes!" Why couldn't they just let her be? She gets up from her position on the ground. "I already told you, I'm doing this for your safety!"

"Don't we get a say in this too?" Adora supposes Glimmer has a point, "What about your safety Adora? How are you going to live out here in the woods?"

"I'll figure it out." Adora knows it's a childish and petty answer, but what was she going to admit, that she hadn't thought that far ahead? That seconds ago she was completely prepared to be devoured by something living in these woods?

Always the voice of reason between Adora and Glimmer, Bows sighs, "Okay, clearly arguing like this won't get us anywhere. But Adora, can you please just hear us out? We didn't come all this way just to start another shouting match."

Adora really just wants to leave. She doesn't want to have this conversation. She wants to get out of here so no one can find her. At least, she thinks that's what she wants.

She's never been good at knowing what she truly wants, because that never mattered before. At the Horde, it was what the higher-ups wanted. What Shadow Weaver wanted. Even in the rebellion, many of Adora's decisions are dictated by what the rebellion needed, what they needed She-Ra for. So could you blame her for being a bit indecisive?

Too exhausted to argue further, Adora falls back to the ground and motions for Bow and Glimmer to sit beside her. She concedes, "Fine, go ahead."

The pair silently join her, and they seem to be thinking of what to say next.

To the surprise of no one, Glimmer goes first. "You know, seeing She-Ra like that in the Northern Reach…it was scary. I mean, it didn't seem like you were in there at all."

Oh so they did know she was dangerous! Great. Why are they even here then? Adora hears Bow chastising Glimmer in the background.

"Wait! I'm not done." Great, what other ways can she confirm Adora's worst fears? "Yes, it was scary. And yes, when She-Ra elbowed me, it hurt! Kinda a lot…but that wasn't you. That wasn't your fault! When that happened, I wasn't thinking 'oh Adora's dangerous now' or whatever you've told yourself in your head. I was just worried about you, worried about how this disk would affect you, whether you would even come back."

That was…that was a lot. Could it be possible that Adora just misread everything? She still doesn't get why Bow and Glimmer aren't wary of her, blaming her, but it seems like for all intents and purposes they aren't. And Adora doesn't know what to do with that. Which is why she doesn't say anything, and Bow has to fill the silence.

"Glimmer and I aren't scared of you, Adora. And even if She-Ra going berserk was something you had any agency over, we still

wouldn't be. You'd never hurt us on purpose, would you?"

What kind of question is that? "No, never!"

"Exactly, so why would we be afraid? We know you Adora. What happened in the Northern Reach, that wasn't you. That wasn't on you."

She just doesn't understand. Back in the Horde, everything was her responsibility. A missed shot, a rock that tripped her, a wayward Catra running in the halls. But here, for some reason they completely refuse to see that. "But I'm She-Ra, so wasn't it me? I'm the one responsible."

"No," Bow and Glimmer say simultaneously.

Adora finally lets herself take a good look at her friends before turning away from them, she says, incredulously, "I just don't get it."

She feels Bow put a hand on her shoulder and she lets it be. Whether that's because she's too tired or she truly welcomes the touch, she doesn't exactly know. "Get what?" He asks.

"Why are you guys being so nice to me?" Adora says, finally, "I failed, I *failed.* As She-Ra, I'm supposed to protect you guys, but all I did was attack you because Catra tricked me! If I had figured out their plan sooner…"

Bow interrupts, "Adora, there's no way you could've guessed that they were going to do that to you. None of us saw it coming."

Adora wants to believe that, but wouldn't that just be her making excuses, finding a way out of accepting her failures? "But…"

"No buts!" Glimmer cuts in, "Just because you're She-Ra doesn't mean you have to be perfect, that you have to be all-knowing or whatever."

Adora supposes that makes a little sense, but she's still worried. What if she's still unsafe? "How can you be so sure this won't happen again?"

"We won't let it," Glimmer says, eyes hard in determination, "The disk may be gone, but we'll make sure no one gets any tech even close to your sword again."

"Glimmer's right. If anyone failed at the Northern Reach, it's us for letting the Horde do that to you. We don't be making that mistake again. The Best Friends Squad looks out for reach other."

That touches something in Adora. For so long, it's just been her. Her against everything. Yes, she had Catra…but that was different. Catra was never asked to bear the same responsibilities, the same pressures, as Adora. So while she was always supportive, she never shared those burdens. But now, with Bow and Glimmer, here they are, volunteering to take the load off of Adora's back. To *protect* her, like she always protects them. It's something new, it's something kind, it's…Adora likes it.

Adora feels a smile, a real smile, on her face for the first time in far too long, "We do, don't we?"

Bow smiles even brighter, "That's the spirit!" He says as he rises to his feet. He holds a hand out for Adora, and she takes it. "Now, sounds to me like it's time for a—"

"Group hug!" Glimmer finishes the thought, and Adora has no time to react before she's tackled by a laughing Glimmer. Bow joins the hug too.

Adora spends a minute tucked in the warm embrace, and it's easily the happiest she's been in a while. She knows that her friends have her back.

Once the hug ends, Adora apologizes for worrying her friends, and they reassure her that there's nothing to apologize for, even if Adora doesn't quite believe that. Bow also challenges her to not

say sorry anymore, and while Adora never backs down from a challenge, she isn't sure if she'll be able to win this one.

"Now, why don't we go back home?" Glimmer suggests, "The Woods are pretty, but the only thing I wanna see right now are my pillows."

Adora chuckles, "I'd much rather see your pillows than mine, I think I've been seeing a little too much of my room lately." The trio begin walking back to the castle.

In front of her, Bow gasps theatrically, "You know what this calls for—Best Friends Squad sleepover!"

Adora feels like she can fly.

After a few hours of trekking and sleepover shenanigans, the three are back in Glimmer's room. Adora's the only one awake now, and she stares at the ceiling.

It's not that she's worried or scared. Nothing of the sort. Truth be told, she's more content than she's ever been in her whole life.

It's just, she feels like there's something she needs to do. A loose end she needs to tie up. It nags at the back of her head like a rope being pulled as she lays down to rest. She knows what it is. What else could it be?

Adora closes her eyes, trying to catch the sleep that eludes her, but she knows it's a futile effort. She must do this, and she has to do this now.

She quietly makes her way to her room, and when she goes inside, she sees the Sword of Protection sitting there, exactly where she left it, shining, even in the dark of the night. Approaching it slowly, she squeezes her eyes shut and rests her shaking hand on the hilt.

Exactly nothing happens.

She doesn’t even feel different. Of course, she hasn’t even transformed. If she’s going to be comfortable with being She-Ra again, there’s only one thing she can do.

If Bow and Glimmer knew what she was thinking of right now, they’d tell her to go back to her comfortable pile of blankets and pillows on the floor and get some rest, she doesn’t have to fix everything immediately.

It's a good thing that they’re asleep.

Adora takes the sword and silently slips out of her room, going down the castle corridor. A couple of turns takes her to her destination.

Fresh air hits her as she opens the door and walks forward.

She stands in one of the castle’s many gardens, holding her sword tightly. She takes a deep breath, and she says the words that have become second nature.

“For the honor of Grayskull!”

Adora comes home again.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you all for reading! I really enjoyed writing this chapter, I love writing Adora’s POV so much. As always, there are some things I don’t enjoy (I think it may be a touch repetitive, but also tbf it’s mostly thoughts and thoughts are very repetitive) but overall I’m pretty happy with how this turned out. I'm just glad I could get it done before university starts back up again.
>
> Also, thanks to everyone who left me a comment/kudos and those who subbed to the story! I love the support!
>
> If you enjoyed, please consider leaving me a comment or a kudos! I love reading all the comments you guys send in, y'all

are so nice!!

(psst, follow my twitter! (yes it's an mcu twitter but it's multifandom when i want it to be))

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